

Isaac Brito-Morales, Ph.D.

Senior Associate Scientist, Conservation International · Research Associate, UC Santa Barbara

Conservation International, Arlington, United States

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Academic and Research Appointments

Senior Associate Scientist

Conservation International, Moore Center for Science

Arlington, United States

Jul 2024 – Present

Associate Research Scientist

Conservation International, Moore Center for Science

Arlington, United States

Nov 2021 – Jun 2024

Research Associate

University of California, Santa Barbara, Marine Science Institute

Santa Barbara, United States

Nov 2024 – Present

Affiliated Researcher

University of California, Santa Barbara, Marine Science Institute

Santa Barbara, United States

Jan 2022 – Oct 2024

Postdoctoral Research Fellow

University of Queensland, School of Mathematics and Physics

Brisbane, Australia

Feb 2021 – Sep 2021

Project Manager

Centro de Ecología Aplicada

Chile

Oct 2010 – Jul 2016

Lecturer in Experimental Design

Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

Mar 2008 – Dec 2009

Education

Ph.D. Biological Sciences

University of Queensland

Brisbane, Australia

2016 – 2021

B.Sc. 1st Class Hons, Marine Biology

Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

2003 – 2008

Grants and Funded Research

Save the Blue Five – IKI Project

International Climate Initiative, BMUV/Germany; co-lead scientific work on climate-change vulnerability, ocean-climate projections, species distribution modelling, conservation planning, and partner engagement

Eastern Tropical Pacific

2023 – Present

Belmont Forum / Ocean Front Change Project

Contributor to international research on climate change, dynamic ocean features, and marine megafauna

International

2021 – 2024

Scholarly Publications

Peer-Reviewed Articles

9. Sanz-Martín M, Olguin-Jacobson C, Bolin JA, Quiles-Pons C, **Brito-Morales I**, García Molinos J, Hidalgo M, Alabía ID, Gissi E, Provost MM, Micheli F, Arafeh-Dalmau N. 2026. Identifying marine climate refugia to advance climate-smart conservation. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution* 41(7), 651–667. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2026.04.007>.
8. Buenafe KCV, Dunn DC, Metaxas A, Schoeman DS, Everett JD, Pidd A, Hanson JO, Bentley LK, Kim SW, Neubert S, Scales KL, Dabalà A, **Brito-Morales I**, Richardson AJ. 2025. Current approaches and future opportunities for climate-smart protected areas. *Nature Reviews Biodiversity*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s44358-025-00041-0>.
7. Sanz-Martín M, Hidalgo M, Puerta P, García Molinos J, Zamanillo M, **Brito-Morales I**, González-Irusta JM, Esteban A, Punzón A, García-Rodríguez E, Vivas M, López-López L. 2024. Climate velocity drives unexpected southward patterns of species shifts in the Western Mediterranean Sea. *Ecological Indicators*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ecolind.2024.111741>.
6. Schoeman DS, Sen Gupta A, Harrison CS, Everett J, **Brito-Morales I**, Hannah L, Bopp L, Roehrdanz P, Richardson AJ. 2023. Demystifying global climate models for use in the life sciences. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2023.04.005>.
5. Buenafe KCV, Dunn D, Everett J, **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, Hanson JO, Dabalà A, Neubert S, Cannicci S, Kaschner K, Richardson AJ. 2023. A metric-based framework for climate-smart conservation planning. *Ecological Applications*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1002/eap.2852>.
4. **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, Everett J, Klein CJ, Dunn D, García Molinos J, Burrows MT, Buenafe KCV, Dominguez RM, Possingham HP, Richardson AJ. 2022. Towards climate-smart, three-dimensional protected areas for biodiversity conservation in the high seas. *Nature Climate Change* 12, 402–407. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-022-01323-7>.
3. Arafeh-Dalmau N, **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, Possingham HP, Klein CJ, Richardson AJ. 2021. Incorporating climate velocity into the design of climate-smart networks of marine protected areas. *Methods in Ecology and Evolution*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1111/2041-210X.13675>.
2. **Brito-Morales I**, Schoeman DS, García Molinos J, Burrows MT, Klein CJ, Arafeh-Dalmau N, Kaschner K, Garilao C, Kesner-Reyes K, Richardson AJ. 2020. Climate velocity reveals increasing exposure of deep-ocean biodiversity to future warming. *Nature Climate Change* 10, 576–581. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41558-020-0773-5>.
1. **Brito-Morales I**, García Molinos J, Schoeman DS, Burrows MT, Poloczanska ES, Brown CJ, Ferrier S, Harwood TD, Klein CJ, McDonald-Madden E, Moore PJ, Pandolfi JM, Watson JEM, Wenger AS, Richardson AJ. 2018. Climate velocity can inform conservation in a warming world. *Trends in Ecology & Evolution* 33, 441–457. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tree.2018.03.009>.

Commentaries and Perspectives

- Hannah L, Irvine A, **Brito-Morales I**, Fuller S, Davies T, Tittensor D, Reville G, Shackell N, Hennicke J, Stanley R. 2024. To save the high seas, plan for climate change. *Nature Comment*. DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1038/d41586-024-01720-2>.

Brito-Morales I, Egorova Y, Hannah L, Ortuño Crespo G, Arafeh-Dalmau N. Evolving area-based conservation for a dynamic ocean. *In review*.

Hannah L, Ramnath S, Scales KL, Rossi V, Sequeira A, Davies TE, Hazen E, Dunn D, Miller PI, Laran S, Falabella V, Gonzales L-A, **Brito-Morales I**. Ocean fronts concentrate fishing pressure on threatened megafauna. *Manuscript in revision*.

Brito-Morales I, Dewitte B, Sudre F, Rohner CA, Hazen EL, Scales KL, Le Corre M, Jaeger A, Laran S, Bousquet O, Sequeira AMM, Davies TE, Dunn DC, Nel R, Hannah L, Rossi V. Megafauna show pervasive yet distinct affinity to ocean fronts: the urgent need for adaptive conservation in a warming world. *Communications Biology*. In review. Preprint DOI: <https://doi.org/10.1101/2025.06.17.660201>

Instruction

Santa Barbara, United States

UCSB, ESM240 Climate Change Biology (graduate course)

2023. 2025

- Designed and delivered graduate-level lectures, practical work, assignments, student projects, and assessment.

Brisbane, Australia

University of Queensland; Advanced Analysis of Scientific Data, Analysis of Scientific Data,
Pharmacy – Data Analysis & Professional Practice, Probability & Statistics in Engineering,
Environmental Data Analysis, and Biostatistics & Experimental Design

2018–2020

Graduate Supervision and Mentoring

Academic Service and Leadership

Organizer

CERFACS, Climate and Ocean Modeling Workshop: Applications of Regional Ocean Models for Marine Megafauna Conservation in the Southeast Pacific

Toulouse, France

2025

Organizer

Conservation International, Climate Change and Marine Megafauna Workshop

David, Panama

2025

Invited Workshop Contributor

Acadia University, Ocean Front, Megafauna and Climate Change

Wolfville, Canada

2024

Invited Workshop Contributor

Nelson Mandela University, Ocean Front and Climate Change

Gqeberha, South Africa

2023

Invited Talks and Seminars

Cambio climático en el océano: la dimensión ignorada en conservación

Encuentro del Pacífico Sudeste

Ciudad de Panamá, Panamá

2024

Climate velocity in the ocean and its implications for conservation

ASLO, S-69: Promoting Resilience Through Climate-Smart Fisheries and Conservation Management

Palma de Mallorca, Spain

2023

Contributed Conference Presentations

Ocean Front Change, Belmont Forum Session: Oceans 2018 End-term

Sustainability, Research & Innovation Congress

Helsinki, Finland

2024

Managing dynamic ocean front ecosystems for species on the move

Species on the Move

Bonita Springs, United States

2023

Climate velocity in the ocean and its implications for conservation

IMPAC5

Vancouver, Canada

2023

Challenges and opportunities for managing ocean front ecosystems in a warming world

Ocean Sciences Meeting

Online

2022

Life below the ocean surface increasingly threatened by climate change

Species on the Move

Kruger National Park, South Africa

2019

Awards and Honors

Academic Excellence

Science Faculty, Universidad Católica de la Santísima Concepción

Concepción, Chile

2008

Languages and References

Fluent Spanish; Fluent English